

SOP-VEH-05: Fleet Vehicle Loading, Weight Limits & Maintenance Policy

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1. Vehicle Loading Requirements & Weight Distribution

Proper vehicle loading is critical to highway safety, vehicle stability, and regulatory compliance.

Axle Weight Balance

- Cargo weight must be distributed evenly across all vehicle axles:
- Maintain an 80/20 axle balance between drive axles and trailer tandem axles.
- Never concentrate heavy freight at the rear bumper (tail-heavy loads cause fatal sway).
- Heavy pallets must be placed over trailer axles and centered along the longitudinal centerline.

Maximum Gross Vehicle Weight Rating (GVWR)

- Class 8 Heavy Tractor-Trailers: Maximum 80,000 lbs (36,287 kg) gross vehicle weight.
- Class 7 Medium Heavy Straight Trucks: Maximum 33,000 lbs (14,968 kg) gross vehicle weight.
- Class 6 Box Trucks: Maximum 26,000 lbs (11,793 kg) gross vehicle weight.
- Overweight loads are strictly prohibited from dispatch without special heavy-haul permits.

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2. Cargo Securing & Restraint Standards

- Ratchet Strapping: Minimum of two (2) heavy-duty 4-inch ratchet straps for every 10 linear feet of cargo bed.
- Double-Stacked Pallets: Must utilize anti-slip rubber friction mats and rigid corner edge protectors.
- Load Bars & Shoring Beams: Mandatory installation of spring-loaded shoring beams behind the final row of cargo.
- Hazardous Materials (HAZMAT) Separation: Toxic, corrosive, and flammable materials must maintain mandatory 3-foot separation between each other.

3. Mandatory Daily Pre-Trip Walkaround Inspection

Drivers must perform and log a 15-minute pre-trip vehicle inspection before starting any route:

1. Steer Tire Tread: Minimum tread depth of 4/32 inch; drive and trailer tires minimum 2/32 inch.
2. Air Brake Pressure: Minimum air pressure 100 PSI; verify low-pressure audible warning alarms.
3. Lighting & Reflectors: Clean and verify headlights, high beams, brake lights, and turn signals.
4. Reefer Telemetry: For refrigerated units, verify fuel level > 75% and temperature setpoint.